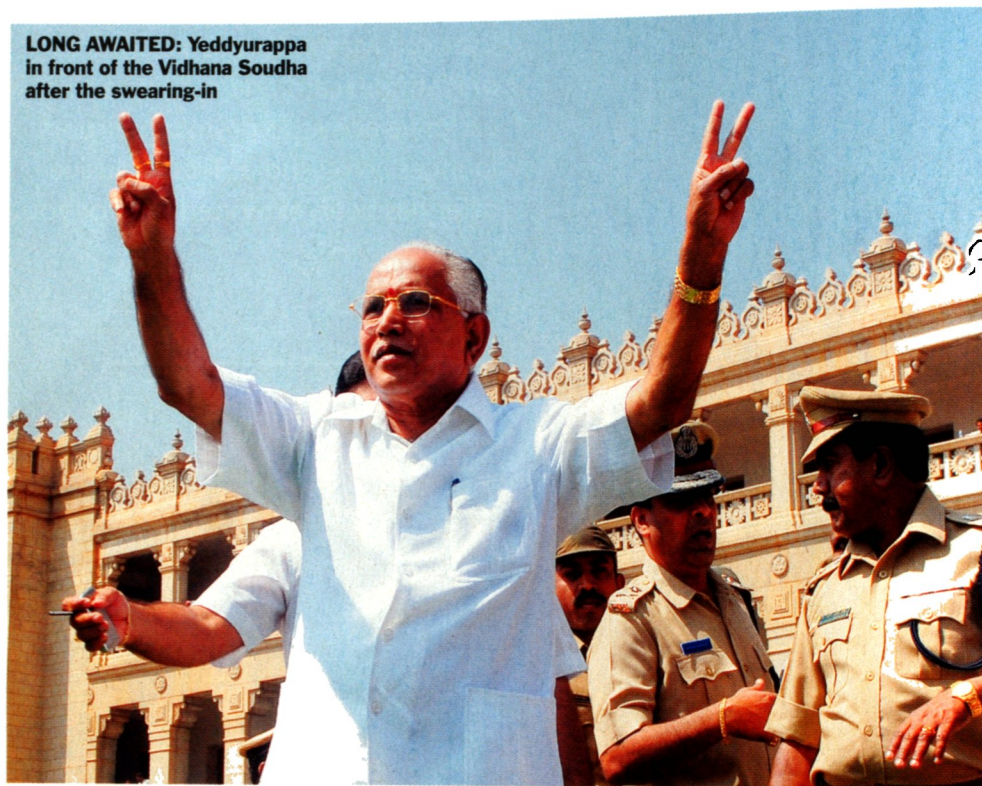


LONG AWAITED: Yeddyurappa in front of the Vidhana Soudha after the swearing-in



ON A WISH AND A PRAYER

The intensely religious Yeddyurappa will need all the help from above to deal with avaricious colleagues and the Gowda clan which will do anything to ensure it has a share in every pie

■ **By Stephen David**

It was a phone call that B.S. Yeddyurappa had been waiting for over a month and came at the end of a pilgrimage that has probably changed his life forever. On November 8, as he stepped out of the Vaishno Devi temple, his cellphone rang. It was Yashwant Sinha, former Union minister and BJP's pointman for Karnataka, calling to give him the news he had been praying for: Governor Rameshwar Thakur had invited him to form a new government in Bangalore.

Yeddyurappa's faith in God and his fetish for numerology—just a

fortnight ago, he replaced the 'i' in his name with a 'd' on an astrologer's advice—has obviously paid off. And in the four days before he was sworn in on November 12, he did thanksgiving rounds of at least a dozen temples, several astrologers and numerous swamis including the supreme pontiff of the state's largest caste group, the Lingayats. He rounded it off with a dip in the river Cauvery before heading to Bangalore to take over as the state's 25th chief minister.

But Yeddyurappa has set off on the task of governance knowing that in Karnataka politics, while God may propose, it is Gowda who disposes.

H.D. Deve Gowda, that is. The unpredictable Gowda, who called it "his saddest day" when his son H.D. Kumaraswamy joined hands with BJP to form the government last year, found nothing wrong in patching up with the same party and offering unconditional support but only after the Congress snubbed all his efforts to cobble up a coalition. Gowda is also known to set tough terms. He and Kumaraswamy have laid down 12 commandments to which strict adherence is being sought. Expectedly, Gowda did not show up at BJP's maiden entry to power in south India, which was graced by a galaxy of top party leaders and attended by

"We are keen that the saffron agenda does not come to the fore."

H.D. KUMARASWAMY, FORMER CHIEF MINISTER